

UNDERCOVER

Sizzle and burn

Agent 001 is on the blazing trail, tracking that invaluable asset for PC users—the blank CD-R

Illustration: Maresh Benkar



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Work hard, play even harder, that's my motto in life. As much as I enjoy each mission that comes my way, nothing beats the pleasure of sitting in my easy chair back home and enjoying the DivX version of *The Planet of the Apes*, or for that matter burning rubber with *Need for Speed*. And to think that these pleasures do come cheap...the price of a blank CD-R to be precise! That's right, blank CDs are a PC enthusiast's best friend. The Indian market, in recent times, has been flooded with CDs of every type and capacity. The choices, I was told, were wide, ranging from manufacturers, dye types to various sizes and formats. So I decided to go see for myself and get the cheapest and best possible CD-R in town.

My first stop—the mecca of hardware and the 'find-it-all-in-one-place-galli', Lamington road! The first shop I walked into stocked only branded media, namely, HP, Sony, etc. Expensive too! Starting from Rs 60 and above. When I asked for something cheaper, the dealer expressed an obvious distaste. He went into a lengthy sermon on how, with cheaper CD-Rs infiltrating the market, the general non-discerning consumers were ending up with inferior quality CD-Rs. He went on to say that these CD-Rs could even spoil your hardware (the CD writer). What he said had some truth in it though, as cheaper CD-Rs use low quality dyes (dye is the organic layer on which the actual recording takes place). You should generally stick with gold pigments. CD-Rs that have green or blue pigments or their variants usually use low

quality dyes, don't have a long life and generate errors while writing.

I also dug up some dirt on 80-minute CD-Rs. Rumour has it that while these CDs have problems with certain CD writers, the market is flooded with them. The second shop I visited in Andheri (W) in Mumbai had an entire spindle (containing 100 CDs) for Rs 1,750. Wow! A blank 700-MB CD-R (80 minutes) for less than Rs 18! I was also told that I could avail of cheaper but unbranded variants. Cheap CD-Rs come without jewel cases and inlay cards, so storage could be a problem unless you plan on buying a CD pouch. Funnily, the vendors would insist on the good value of the CDs they stocked and would at times go to the extent of saying that other CDs were fakes and hence cheaper. Pester them further and out would come long spindles full of cheap CDs.

Onto shop number three, also in Andheri, and I was offered an entire spindle containing 100 CDs for less than Rs 12 a CD, though all were unbranded and didn't offer any guarantee. Another disadvantage with these spindles is that they come in large numbers and don't sell in smaller quantities, forcing you to buy the entire lot. And the dealer couldn't say whether these CDs would run on all CD writers.

Well, at the end of the hunt, here's what my investigations told me: 80-minute CD-Rs can be written to by almost any CD writer, but certain manufacturers such as HP and Sony do not officially support the 80-minute format. Add to this the issues with certain CD-writing software—some even fail to correctly detect the 80-minute

format. This is because these CD-Rs do not comply with the CD Red-Book standard, jointly developed by Philips and Sony. (Audio tracks on Red-Book discs are stored at 44,100 Hz, 16 bits, stereo and have a defined track spiral.) Nevertheless, these CDs have become the rage and are slowly replacing the 74-minute (650 MB) format. You can easily avail of these CDs from most vendors and choose from among brands such as TDK, BASF, SUPER, Frontech, Dysan, Traxdata, Maxell, Imation, Kodak, Samsung...the list is endless!

So go make burning a habit. Emperor Nero would be proud! 📀

Want to share your experiences with buying and burning CD-Rs?
Write in to readersletters@jasubhai.com

CD-ROM File Systems

To access any file, a computer's operating system needs to be able to locate the file. A file system facilitates the storage and retrieval of hundreds or even thousands of distinct files. Every operating system uses a different file system and therefore there are a number of CD-ROM file systems in use on Windows, Macintosh, Unix and others. The most common file systems for CD-ROMs are the ISO 9660 and Joliet extensions. ISO 9660 is the international standard and is

designed for the PC and MSDOS. The Joliet specification was designed to resolve certain deficiencies of the original ISO 9660 file system such as a limited character set and file name and path lengths. CD-ROMs that are to be used on Macintosh computers are usually created in the Hierarchical Filing System (HFS) format. This format features support for subdirectories, up to 31 characters per file name and up to 27 characters for volume names.